
**Unit 1, Option A,
Topic A7: The
Reign of Henry VII,
1485-1509**

The focus of this topic is the reign of the first Tudor monarch from his triumph at Bosworth Field until his death. Since the focus of Unit 1 is on broad themes, questions will not be set which concentrate exclusively on depth of knowledge, for example about one particular individual or event, other than those which are specifically listed in the specification bullet points. Students will, however, be expected to demonstrate their understanding of the themes defined in the specification bullet points by the selection and deployment of relevant information as exemplification.

Collectively, the four bullet points of the specification offer a framework for understanding the themes of the consolidation and exercise of royal power and the challenges to that power in the reign of Henry VII. Bullet points cannot be taken in complete isolation from one another and students should develop an appreciation of links between them. For example, foreign aid from Margaret of Burgundy played an important part in heightening the threat in 1487 from Simnel and Suffolk (bullet points 1 and 4) and the Treaty with France in 1492 enhanced Henry's revenue (bullet points 3 and 4).

The first bullet point relates to Henry's triumph at Bosworth and the subsequent steps taken in 1485-86 to assert and consolidate his claim to the throne. This involves his use of Parliament and marriage to Elizabeth. Students need to be aware of the nature of his claim and the consequent threats from rivals. The challenges to royal power and Henry's success in seeing off rivals can be illustrated by studies of Lambert Simnel's and John de la Pole's rebellion, the career of Perkin Warbeck between 1491 and 1499, the execution of Warwick in 1499 and the imprisonment of Richard de la Pole in 1506.

The second bullet point relates to the nature of royal power in the late 15th century and of the crucial role of the nobility in the localities. This can be addressed through examples of Henry's use of the nobility and his methods to control and limit their potential to challenge royal authority through such instruments as bonds and the regulation of retaining.

The third bullet point relates to Henry's administration of justice and royal finance. Students should understand the ways in which these did or did not contribute to Henry's control. Was Henry successful in law enforcement? The growth in royal revenue was clearly central to the revival of royal power and this process might be illustrated by his revenue-raising (ordinary and extraordinary) at home, his use of the Exchequer and the Chamber to collect revenue, and through the careers of Reginald Bray and latterly Empson and Dudley. Challenges to the process of improving royal revenue could be illustrated by the events in Yorkshire in 1489 and Cornwall in 1497. Specific questions, however, will not be set on these individuals and events.

The fourth bullet point relates to Henry's relations with Spain, France, Burgundy and Scotland, how far his foreign policy was determined by the desire to consolidate his power and minimise challenge, and how far his foreign policy was successful in enhancing his power at home and prestige abroad. These themes can be illustrated by brief consideration of the wars with Scotland and France and important treaties such as Medina del Campo, Radon, Etaples, the Intercursus Magnus, Ayrton and Windsor. These events and treaties, however, will not be the subject of specific questions.